

Describe and explain an educational experience or an observation of teaching and/or learning using what you now know of Psychology.

Section 1:

Prior to undertaking this degree in Maths & Education, I had a rather narrow view of what was involved in teaching, and what was required to be capable of teaching to a high standard. I believed that teaching was simply a vague combination of curriculum knowledge and practical experience; modules such as the Psychology of Education and Sociology of Education have helped me to realise the importance of the theory behind teaching and learning, and of the context in which they take place.

The introduction to major psychological theories that this year has provided has allowed me to think critically of my educational experiences by providing context which I had no understanding of before. This assignment will lay out an example of such an educational experience, explain the psychological theories that have allowed me to understand the experience from a psychological perspective and describe what I now understand from it.

Having attended an all-Irish primary school as well as an all-Irish secondary school, it's safe to say that the Irish language has always made up a large part of my education. When I need to solve a difficult mathematical problem in my mind I think about it all through Irish. Whenever I sneeze I automatically follow it up with a quick 'gabh mo leithscéal', despite the fact that neither of my parents can speak Irish and it was never spoken at home. Irish comes naturally to me and I'm as comfortable speaking it now as I am English. The primary school I attended was well-funded and had all the resources available to them to ensure that every student had a solid foundation in all subjects before secondary school. I can remember being fond of Irish at a young age, and am fond of Irish now, but there was a period of time during secondary school where my standard of Irish as well as my interest in the language dropped significantly.

My first year of secondary school was also one of the first years that the school had 60 pupils in each year, as opposed to 30, which meant that the school needed to hire extra teachers. During 1st and 2nd year, I had a freshly-graduated Irish teacher from Monday to Wednesday and the school's older and more experienced Irish teacher on Thursdays and Fridays.

Each of these two teachers had very different teaching methods. The newer teacher found the class difficult to control from the start, and began using group punishment as a means to stop students from messing. This meant, for example, that if someone was asking a question out of place, the teacher would give them multiple warnings and after that the entire class would get extra work. Despite the fact that punishments and warnings were handed out on a daily basis, we as students had no idea what behaviour would warrant what punishment. Unfortunately,

as there was no explanation of learning outcomes or goals, it felt as though I spent most of my 1st and 2nd year doing extra work due to the behaviour of others.

This contrasted greatly with the Irish classes I had on Thursdays and Fridays with the more experienced teacher. At the beginning of the year he informed us of what we were to be learning throughout the year. Each week we had a certain amount of Irish grammar rules to learn and practice, and if everyone got through all the work during the week then there would be no work left to do as homework for the weekend. The same group of students that would be disruptive throughout from Monday-Wednesday were calm and enjoyed working through this Irish work so that they had none left to do as homework. My interest in Irish dropped significantly in these first two years of secondary school, and later returned to normal in around 5th year.

Section 2:

Learning, as outlined by fd), occurs when “experience (including practice) causes a relatively permanent change in an individual’s knowledge or behaviour.” It is evident from this definition that learning happens through interaction with the learner’s environment, and results in a change in their knowledge or behaviour. Most psychologists would agree with this statement; some, however, would emphasize the change in knowledge and some others would focus on the behavioural change. It is the belief of cognitive psychologists that learning is solely an internal mental activity and thus cannot be observed. Cognitive psychologists studying learning place focus solely on mental process such as remembering, thinking and problem solving (Schwartz, Wasserman, & Robbins, 2002). In contrast, behavioural psychology attributes the outcome of learning to an observable change in behaviour. Early behaviourists such as J. B. Watson held the radical position that because “mentalisms” such as thinking could not be observed or “studied rigorously and scientifically” they should not even be included in an explanation of learning (Woolfolk, 2013, p.246).

The behavioural approach to learning highlights the importance of the connections that children make between experiences and behaviour. Santrock (2009, p.255) explains that classical conditioning is the process through which a “neutral stimulus” (such as the sight of a dog) becomes associated with a “meaningful stimulus” (such as a frightening noise) and “acquires the capacity to elicit a similar response”. Originally developed by a Russian physiologist by the name of Ivan Pavlov (1849-1936), classical conditioning results in “the learning of involuntary emotional or physiological responses such as fear, increased muscle tension, salivation, or sweating” (Woolfolk, 2013, p.248). Long (2000, p.13) provides an example which outlines just one of the ways that classical conditioning can have an impact on students’ education: if a child fails an exam and is heavily criticized to a point which produces anxiety, then the child may begin to associate exams with anxiety, thus making exams a “conditioned stimulus” for anxiety. Long (2000, p.14) goes on to explain that when

learners become classically conditioned, they learn to “predict” what follows certain stimuli and their involuntary response is a result of this “expectancy”.

B. F. Skinner (1904-1990), the American psychologist responsible for developing the concept of operant conditioning, was of the opinion that “the principles of classical conditioning account for only a small portion of learned behaviours” (Woolfolk, 2013, p.250). Operant conditioning, in comparison, is a “form of learning in which the consequences of behaviour produce changes in the probability that the behaviour will occur” (Santrock, 2009, p.256). Consequences may consist of reinforcements or punishments, depending on whether the behaviour in question is favourable or unfavourable.

Donahue (2008) explains that the use of reinforcements results in a behaviour being strengthened and promoted. With positive reinforcement, the behaviour in question increases in frequency because it is met with a rewarding stimulus. Long (2000, p.14) provides the example of “receiving praise for doing well in a test”, which might “encourage future studying”. Negative reinforcement also increases the frequency of preferred behaviours, but by removing something unpleasant or “aversive” in response. An example of negative reinforcement would be having all students clean the class at the end of school, except for the table that do best in their homework. This removal of an aversive stimulus might encourage the students to work harder on their homework.

Alberto & Troutman (2006) introduce the concept of applied behaviour analysis, which involves applying the principles of operant conditioning in situations such as education in order to shape and control students’ behaviour. In order to decrease children’s undesirable behaviour, Alberto & Troutman (2006) recommend this order of the following steps:

1. Reinforce behaviour that is preferred.
2. Terminate reinforcement of the child.
3. Remove desirable stimuli from the child.
4. Present aversive stimuli (punishment).

Long (2000, p.14) insists that the use of positive and negative reinforcement in order to promote desirable behaviours is much more effective than the use of punishment to decrease undesirable behaviours. Punishments do not emphasise new, desirable behaviour and if the student is seeking attention then they may see the punishment as a type of reinforcement if they also get a reaction from the class. Punishments also make for the person who administers the punishment to be seen in a negative way, meaning that a student who is being punished “is unlikely to generate any spontaneous co-operative behaviour” towards the teacher in the future.

Section 3:

The psychological theories mentioned in Section 2 above have allowed me to think critically of the educational experience I described in Section 1. Personally, I can see what factors were involved that conditioned my opinion towards Irish during the first few years of secondary school.

Unfortunately, the way that the less experienced Irish teacher managed behaviour in the class went against the outlines set out in applied behaviour analysis. The students were expected to carry out the work as instructed, and if there was misbehaviour or a low standard of work then aversive stimuli were presented. As seen above, the use of aversive stimuli is recommended as a last resort, as there are many options that are more effective.

Unbeknownst to the teacher, she may also have acted in a way that rewarded bad behaviour. Sometimes she would humour misbehaving students by responding to their jokes with a smarter joke, and getting a reaction from the class. I know now that this may be interpreted as positive reinforcement and probably didn't help the situation.

I agree with Long's (2000, p.14) warning that the use of punishment may result in the teacher being seen in a negative way. I certainly found that students began to see the teacher in a negative way, but I also found, due to nature of the group punishments being used, that the students who were misbehaving were seen in a negative way by their peers. Although this may seem as an acceptable way to control behaviour, I feel as though it is irresponsible to have a situation that causes conflict and possible complications (bullying etc.) between students.

When thinking back to my Irish class with the more experienced teacher I found it odd that I could not remember many instances of punishment. I now realise this was due to his skilful use of applied behaviour analysis. The introduction at the beginning of the year of a clear learning plan allowed him to consistently provide positive reinforcement in the form of praise for topics we were doing well in, or negative reinforcement in allowing us to skip homework on a certain night. This reinforcement was enough to remove most if not all misbehaviour from the class.

Despite the Irish classes on Thursday's and Friday's with the more experience teacher being enjoyable, most of my week was spent doing extra Irish work due to constant punishments. Eventually, my annoyance at the behaviour of others became annoyance at the punishments, leading me to become annoyed at Irish itself. This is an example of classical conditioning; the previously neutral stimulus of Irish became conditioned to trigger annoyance, even during 3rd and 4th year of school. It wasn't until 5th year that the response of annoyance decreased and I enjoyed Irish as much as I had previously (extinction).

Section 4:

The introduction to these major psychological theories have allowed me to think critically about my educational experience, and I now see connections and relationships that I had no context for at the time. Having previously thought that teaching was simply "a vague

combination of curriculum knowledge and practical experience”, I now completely disagree with that statement after completing this module.

Personally, in this one reflection, I have found that the actions of a single teacher influenced my opinion of a subject for years and I was oblivious to the mechanics behind this situation at the time. I now believe that it is the responsibility of every teacher to invest sufficient time in researching and understanding educational sciences such as psychology, as their choice of teaching and behavioural control methods can have a bigger impact than may seem evident at the time.

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